

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Quine and Strawson - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 32 diagnostics, 9 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Quine and Strawson - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Quine and Strawson learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 11. □ Two printed limbs, one owner each: the critique of empiricism is **Quine's**, and the theory of basic particulars and persons is **Strawson's**.

Evidence discipline: FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper I.

Terminology and citation rule: the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *sameness of meaning (synonymy)*, *substitution preserving truth (interchangeability salva veritate)*, *stipulated rules of an artificial language (semantical rules)*, *confirmation holism (the web of belief)*, *the whole-system test (the Duhem-Quine thesis)*, *what a theory says there is (ontological commitment)*, *translation from scratch (radical translation)*, *undetermined reference (inscrutability of reference)*, *rival manuals that fit all behaviour (indeterminacy of translation)*, *mapping the scheme we actually use (descriptive metaphysics)*, *picking out and picking out again (identification and re-identification)*, *body-predicates (M-predicates)*, *consciousness-predicates (P-predicates)*, *experiences that belong to nobody (the no-ownership theory)*, *a background condition for a true-or-false use (presupposition)*. Provenance is examinable: "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" is *The Philosophical Review*, **January 1951**, its web passage at **Section 6**; the bound-variable slogan belongs to **"On What There Is" (1948)**, not to "Two Dogmas"; *Individuals* (1959) is cited by **Part I** for basic particulars and **ch. 3** for persons; "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) is **Grice and Strawson** jointly; quantum logic is **Birkhoff and von Neumann (1936)** for the formalism and **Putnam (1968)** for the empirical claim, never merged.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	9
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the provenance, dating, attribution and ownership errors that cost marks every year in this clause.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the owner from the stem first:** five of the nine owned parts are Quine's and four are Strawson's, and no part asks for a joint doctrine.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 to 220 words, 15 marks about 250 to 330, 20 marks about 330 to 400**.
5. Check every answer against the traps: the truncated quotation, the merged Duhem-Quine thesis, the misdated slogan, the "united front" reading of the 1956 paper, the atoms reading of basic particulars, and the refutation of only one of the two rivals to the person concept.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated, and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons* - together with the two-project division and the fence around it, the two classes of analytic truth, each of the three failed explications with its own failure, the exact conclusion Quine draws and the exact conclusion he does not, both forms of reductionism and the identification of the two dogmas at root, the unit of empirical significance, the field-of-force structure with its three revision options, both canonical sentences with their qualifiers, the constraints that block arbitrary revision, the *modus tollens* argument, the scope-and-exemption contrast between Duhem and Quine, the Neptune/Vulcan pair, descriptive against revisionary metaphysics with Strawson's own examples, the question basic particulars answer and the five-step argument that answers it, the three defects of sense-data, the purely auditory world and the analogue of space, the two predicate-classes, the dual character of P-predicates, what "primitive" does and does not mean, and the self-refutation of the no-ownership theory. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause: the provenance of the bound-variable slogan, the two-author two-date structure of the quantum-logic episode, Quine's own later retreat, the "Quine rejects empiricism" misreading, the identity-predicate move in *gavagai*, the four-doctrine taxonomy, the dating of naturalized epistemology, and the ownership fence around Topics 03, 04, 06, 07 and 08.

MCQ 1. How the printed clause divides between its two thinkers

The syllabus prints one heading: *Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons*. Which statement describes the division of labour that the 2018-2025 papers actually respect?

- A. Both limbs are shared, which is why the two philosophers are printed together rather than separately.
- B. Strawson supplies the critique of empiricism and Quine supplies the theory of basic particulars and persons.
- C. Quine supplies the critique of empiricism and Strawson supplies the theory of basic particulars and persons.
- D. Quine supplies both limbs, and Strawson appears only as a commentator on Quine's conclusions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no routed part between 2018 and 2025 asks for a joint doctrine, and the two men publicly disagree about the analytic/synthetic distinction.
- **B:** Incorrect: it reverses the ownership. The two dogmas belong to Quine; *Individuals* belongs to Strawson.
- **C:** Correct: five parts name Quine's material and four name Strawson's, and the division matches the printed limbs exactly.
- **D:** Incorrect: Strawson's basic particulars and persons are printed doctrine in their own right, not commentary.

Examiner trap 1: Writing "the Quine-Strawson critique of empiricism" as though it named one doctrine ignores the only documented exchange between them, which is a disagreement.

MCQ 2. What Quine actually concludes about analyticity

Which statement gives the conclusion of the attack on the first dogma with the precision the paper rewards?

- A. Every sentence traditionally classified as analytic turns out on inspection to be false.
- B. The available explications fail to secure the sharp, non-question-begging boundary that logical empiricism required.
- C. The word "analytic" has no use at all in any language, whether natural or artificially constructed.
- D. Analyticity can be given a precise definition, but only for constructed artificial languages and never for ordinary spoken ones.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Quine never claims that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false; he attacks the explication, not the sentence.
- **B:** Correct: the target is the **foundational** boundary, and the argument is that each candidate explication presupposes a member of the same family.
- **C:** Incorrect: that overstates the result, and Quine concedes that speakers classify cases; his point is that classification is not a principled ground.
- **D:** Incorrect: Carnap's semantical rules do classify sentences in a stipulated language, but Quine's complaint is that this leaves the general notion unexplained.

Examiner trap 2: Inferring from one missing definition that no sentence can ever be called analytic converts a careful negative result into an indefensible claim that the objectors immediately refute.

MCQ 3. The two classes into which analytic truths were said to fall

On the standard account Quine examines, analytic statements fall into two classes. Which pairing is correct?

- A. Truths of arithmetic, and truths established by controlled scientific experiment.
- B. Truths known before experience, and truths known only after sufficient experience.
- C. Truths asserted by explicit definition, and truths asserted by deliberate stipulation in a language manual.
- D. Logical truths, and truths convertible into logical truths by substituting synonyms for synonyms.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: experimental truths are the paradigm of the synthetic; the division concerns kinds of analyticity, not arithmetic against experiment.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the a priori/a posteriori distinction, which is a further casualty of holism rather than the classification under test.
- **C:** Incorrect: definition and stipulation are candidate **explanations** of the second class, not the classes themselves.
- **D:** Correct: "No unmarried man is married" is logically true; "No bachelor is married" becomes so once synonyms are substituted - and it is the second class that needs synonymy.

Examiner trap 3: Starting the answer at "synonymy is circular" without first dividing the analytic truths into the two classes loses the step that shows *why* synonymy is needed at all.

MCQ 4. Why explaining synonymy by definition fails

Quine rejects the appeal to definition as an account of synonymy. What is his reason?

- A. Except in frankly stipulative cases, a definition reports a synonymy that already obtained in the language.
- B. Definitions are always circular in form, since the definiens repeats the definiendum in different words.
- C. Dictionaries disagree with one another, so no definition can command the assent of all speakers.
- D. Definitions belong to lexicography rather than to philosophy and therefore cannot settle logical questions.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the lexicographer is an empirical scientist recording usage; the definition presupposes the very relation it was called in to explain.
- **B:** Incorrect: definitions are not circular in form; the circularity is in the **explanatory order**, not in the sentence.
- **C:** Incorrect: Quine's argument does not rest on disagreement between dictionaries, and empirical variation would not settle the conceptual point.
- **D:** Incorrect: this dismisses definitions by discipline rather than by argument, and Quine grants that stipulative definitions do create synonymy.

Examiner trap 4: Saying merely that "definitions are circular" misstates the objection; the point is that a definition **records** an antecedent synonymy rather than manufacturing one.

MCQ 5. Why interchangeability *salva veritate* fails

Quine tests the proposal that two terms are synonymous when they are interchangeable *salva veritate*. What does he find?

- A. The test is untestable, since no speaker can survey every context in which two terms might occur.
- B. The test presupposes a prior list of analytic sentences drawn up in advance, and therefore cannot be applied to any ordinary spoken language.
- C. The test succeeds for natural kinds but fails for abstract terms such as "number" and "proposition".
- D. In an extensional language it over-generates, and repairing it by requiring interchange within necessity-contexts presupposes analyticity.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the objection is not practical difficulty but the logical structure of the test and of its proposed repair.
- **B:** Incorrect: the test does not presuppose a list; the presupposition Quine identifies is the intelligibility of **necessity**.
- **C:** Incorrect: the standard counter-case, "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney", uses ordinary biological terms rather than abstract ones.
- **D:** Correct: coextensive but non-synonymous terms interchange freely in extensional contexts, and the necessity-operator repair returns to the notion under examination.

Examiner trap 5: Omitting the "creature with a heart / creature with a kidney" illustration leaves the over-generation charge asserted rather than shown, and the illustration costs a single clause.

MCQ 6. What Carnap's semantical rules do and do not deliver

Why does Quine hold that semantical rules for an artificial language L do not explain analyticity?

- A. Carnap's rules are inconsistent, so no sentence can be shown to be analytic-in-L by applying them.
- B. They classify sentences as analytic-in-L, but the general notion of a semantical rule is no clearer than analyticity itself.
- C. Artificial languages cannot be learned by ordinary speakers and so cannot fix meanings for anyone.
- D. The rules apply only to the logical constants of the language, leaving every non-logical vocabulary item entirely unaccounted for.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Quine does not allege inconsistency; he allows that the rules do classify sentences within a stipulated language.
- **B:** Correct: we learn the membership of a list without learning what membership consists in, so the general explanatory notion is untouched.
- **C:** Incorrect: learnability is not the issue, and Quine himself favours regimentation into artificial notation for other purposes.
- **D:** Incorrect: the semantical rules are not restricted to logical constants; the complaint concerns the explanatory status of the device.

Examiner trap 6: Treating "analytic-in-L" as a successful definition of "analytic" concedes the very generality Quine denies, and it is the step Carnap's defenders must argue for rather than assume.

MCQ 7. What the second dogma asserts, and why it bears its name

Which statement identifies reductionism as Quine describes it?

- A. It is the doctrine that all sciences will eventually be reduced to physics and its vocabulary.
- B. It is the doctrine that mental states are nothing over and above states of the physical body.
- C. It is the doctrine that each meaningful statement is individually confirmable by, or translatable into, a range of sense-experience.
- D. It is the doctrine that theoretical terms must always be eliminated in favour of purely observational terms wherever this is possible.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the unity-of-science thesis is a different doctrine and is not what "Two Dogmas" attacks.
- **B:** Incorrect: that is a thesis in philosophy of mind, unrelated to the confirmation-theoretic dogma under examination.
- **C:** Correct: the radical form demands term-by-term translation into experience and the attenuated form assigns each statement its own confirming experiences; the label names the reduction of sentence-meaning to observation sentences.
- **D:** Incorrect: elimination of theoretical terms is one positivist programme among others, and it is not the assumption Quine isolates.

Examiner trap 7: Defining reductionism as "reducing everything to matter" answers a question about metaphysics when the examiner asked about confirmation.

MCQ 8. How Quine relates the two dogmas to each other

What is Quine's own verdict on the relation between the two dogmas?

- A. They are at root identical, since the first requires the sentence-sized confirmation the second supplies.
- B. They are independent assumptions that happen to have been held together by the same philosophers.
- C. The first dogma is a special case of the second, applying only to the sentences of mathematics and formal logic.
- D. The second dogma follows deductively from the first, so refuting the first is sufficient by itself.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: statements "confirmed come what may" need a contrast class of statements individually confirmed, and the second dogma supplies exactly that picture.
- **B:** Incorrect: reporting them as independent items on a list loses the architecture of the paper and the line examiners look for.
- **C:** Incorrect: the first dogma is not restricted to mathematics and logic, and it is not presented as a special case of the second.
- **D:** Incorrect: the dependence runs the other way round in Quine's exposition, and neither is derived from the other by deduction.

Examiner trap 8: Presenting the two dogmas as two unconnected criticisms turns an argument with a structure into a list, which is the difference between the 2024 answer that scores and the one that does not.

MCQ 9. The unit of empirical significance

On Quine's holistic account, what is the unit of empirical significance?

- A. The individual observation sentence, since only observation sentences make direct contact with experience.
- B. The whole of science, since statements face the tribunal of sense experience only as a corporate body.
- C. The single theory under test, together with the instruments used to test it on that occasion.
- D. The individual term, provided it can be given an ostensive definition by a competent speaker.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: observation sentences lie at the periphery, but they are not the unit; the whole system is what meets experience.
- **B:** Correct: this is Quine's formulation, and the corporate-body sentence is the pivot of the paper.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Duhem-Quine point extends beyond the local theory-plus-instrument package to the total system.
- **D:** Incorrect: the term was the unit of the programme that had already failed before "Two Dogmas" was written.

Examiner trap 9: Naming the sentence rather than the whole of science restates the dogma being removed and quietly reverses the doctrine.

MCQ 10. The structure of the web and the options it leaves open

When experience conflicts with a prediction, which set of responses does the web model make available?

- A. Revise a peripheral belief, or abandon the observation entirely, but never touch the interior of the system.
- B. Revise the interior first, since the interior contains the theoretical statements most likely to be responsible for the error.
- C. Revise a peripheral belief, revise a deep interior statement, or plead hallucination and revise the observation statement.
- D. Suspend judgement until further observations settle which particular statement is at fault in the system.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the interior is explicitly revisable - that is what "no statement is immune to revision" asserts.
- **B:** Incorrect: interior statements are the **least** likely to be revised in practice, being the most entrenched.
- **C:** Correct: three options, of which the third is what makes "any statement can be held true come what may" literally true.
- **D:** Incorrect: suspension is not the doctrine; further observation does not identify the guilty statement, since it too meets the system as a whole.

Examiner trap 10: Omitting the option of pleading hallucination removes the very move that guarantees the famous sentence, and the sentence then looks like rhetoric rather than a theorem.

MCQ 11. The exact content of the sentence tested in 2025

The 2025 paper quotes: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." What carries the doctrine?

- A. The opening clause, which asserts that truth is whatever the total system chooses to affirm.
- B. The final conditional clause, which names the cost that disciplines every such affirmation.
- C. The reference to "our total system", which shows that truth is relative to a community's practice.
- D. The phrase "in the face of whatever experience", which shows that experience is evidentially inert.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reading the opening clause alone yields relativism, which the qualifier expressly excludes.
- **B:** Correct: the adjustments elsewhere are the price, and the price is what makes the claim a thesis about holistic confirmation rather than about licence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the phrase locates the claim in a system, but it is the conditional, not the possessive, that carries the doctrine.
- **D:** Incorrect: experience is not inert on Quine's account; it convicts the system and forces revision somewhere.

Examiner trap 11: Quoting the first half of the sentence and calling it relativism is the single commonest way of failing 2025 Q4(b).

MCQ 12. What prevents holism from licensing arbitrary revision

Which combination correctly identifies the constraints Quine places on the choice of revision?

- A. Predictive success, conservatism, simplicity, fecundity and the maxim of minimum mutilation.
- B. The verification principle, together with a rule forbidding the revision of logic under any circumstances.
- C. The analytic/synthetic distinction, retained in an attenuated form for statements of mathematics.
- D. A rule that peripheral statements must always be surrendered before interior statements are touched.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the pragmatic virtues of "Two Dogmas" together with the later maxim of *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **B:** Incorrect: the verification principle is a casualty of the argument, and no absolute prohibition on revising logic is available to Quine.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is what the paper removes; entrenchment replaces it and is not an attenuated version of it.
- **D:** Incorrect: there is no such rule; the whole point is that logic alone does not dictate where revision occurs.

Examiner trap 12: Answering "critically examine" on holism without naming a single constraint leaves the "anything goes" objection unanswered and the verdict unearned.

MCQ 13. What modus tollens delivers in the Duhem-Quine argument

A hypothesis H, with auxiliaries A, entails observation O. Experiment yields not-O. What follows?

- A. H is false, since the auxiliaries were accepted before the test and are therefore not in question.
- B. Not-(H and A): either H is false or some element of A is false, and logic does not say which.
- C. Both H and A are false, since a conjunction whose consequence fails has no true conjuncts.
- D. Nothing at all follows, because an observation report can always be dismissed as unreliable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: prior acceptance confers no immunity; the Uranus case shows an auxiliary being surrendered instead of the hypothesis.
- **B:** Correct: the negation of a conjunction leaves the distribution of blame open, and that openness is the thesis.
- **C:** Incorrect: the negation of a conjunction does not entail the falsity of each conjunct; this is a straightforward logical error.
- **D:** Incorrect: pleading hallucination is one option among three, not a demonstration that nothing follows.

Examiner trap 13: Asserting that "a failed test refutes the hypothesis" restates precisely the assumption the thesis was constructed to remove.

MCQ 14. How Duhem's thesis differs from Quine's

Which contrast between Duhem and Quine is accurate?

- A. Duhem extended the thesis to all knowledge, while Quine restricted it to theoretical physics alone.
- B. Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis, so the compound label records nothing more than joint discovery.
- C. Duhem applied the thesis to logic and mathematics as well as to physics, while Quine deliberately exempted both from revision.
- D. Duhem restricted it to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; Quine extended it to all knowledge and exempted nothing.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it reverses both scopes; Duhem is the narrower of the two.
- **B:** Incorrect: the shared label is later shorthand for two non-identical claims, and saying so is itself a mark.
- **C:** Incorrect: Duhem does not put logic and mathematics at risk, and Quine exempts nothing.
- **D:** Correct: scope and exemptions are precisely where the two claims part, and Quine's extension is the controversial step.

Examiner trap 14: Writing "the Duhem-Quine thesis" without distinguishing its two halves throws away the most examinable precision available on this sub-topic.

MCQ 15. What the Neptune and Vulcan cases jointly demonstrate

Why does a strong answer deploy Neptune and "Vulcan" together rather than Neptune alone?

- A. Because Neptune was discovered by calculation while Vulcan was discovered by direct observation.
- B. Because both episodes show that Newtonian mechanics survives every anomaly that is put to it.
- C. Because the same strategy of revising an auxiliary was correct for Uranus and wrong for Mercury, so no rule fixes the choice in advance.
- D. Because Le Verrier's method of positing an unseen extra planet was later shown to be invalid, which is the reason Vulcan was never found.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: "Vulcan" was never discovered at all, and the contrast is about which revision was correct, not about method of discovery.
- **B:** Incorrect: Newtonian mechanics did **not** survive the Mercury anomaly; general relativity replaced it in 1915.
- **C:** Correct: identical logical situations, opposite correct responses, and no advance rule - which is the thesis, demonstrated historically.
- **D:** Incorrect: the method that found Neptune in 1846 was sound; what differed was which conjunct actually needed revision.

Examiner trap 15: Citing Neptune alone makes holism look like a recipe for saving theories, when the paired case shows it is a claim about the absence of any recipe.

MCQ 16. Descriptive and revisionary metaphysics, with Strawson's own examples

Which statement gives Strawson's distinction together with the examples he himself uses?

- A. Descriptive metaphysics reconstructs the world out of private sense-data (Russell, Carnap); revisionary metaphysics simply describes our ordinary usage (Austin, Ryle).
- B. Descriptive metaphysics is empirical psychology (Hume, Mill); revisionary metaphysics is formal logic (Frege, Russell).
- C. Descriptive metaphysics is done by scientists and revisionary metaphysics by philosophers, which is why the two rarely meet.
- D. Descriptive metaphysics describes the actual structure of our thought (Aristotle, Kant); revisionary metaphysics proposes a better one (Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley).

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: reconstruction from sense-data is the revisionary programme Strawson opposes, and the names are misassigned.
- **B:** Incorrect: descriptive metaphysics is expressly **not** empirical psychology; treating it so misreads its transcendental form.
- **C:** Incorrect: the distinction is between two philosophical projects, not between disciplines.
- **D:** Correct: these are Strawson's own affinities and contrasts, and revisionary metaphysics is at its best in the service of the descriptive.

Examiner trap 16: Giving two definitions with no examples is exactly the fatal error the directive decoder records for this sub-topic.

MCQ 17. The question that "basic particulars" answers

What question is Strawson's theory of basic particulars designed to answer?

- A. Which particulars are such that the possibility of identification and reference in general depends on them?
- B. Which particulars are the smallest, and therefore the ultimate constituents of physical reality?
- C. Which particulars can be perceived directly, without inference from any other particular?
- D. Which particulars persist entirely unchanged through time, and therefore possess a genuine substantial identity?

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: basic particulars are basic in the order of identification, so the question is about the conditions of reference.
- **B:** Incorrect: basic particulars are macroscopic bodies and persons, not microphysical simples.
- **C:** Incorrect: direct perceptibility is the empiricist's criterion, and it selects precisely the sense-data Strawson rules out.
- **D:** Incorrect: enduring is necessary for re-identification, but unchanging substantial identity is a different and stronger demand.

Examiner trap 17: Answering "what is a basic particular?" with a list rather than with the identification-question loses the argument the 2021 stem explicitly asks for.

MCQ 18. The argument from identification and re-identification

Which sequence reproduces Strawson's argument for the basic status of material bodies?

- A. Bodies are publicly observable, and whatever is publicly observable must be real; therefore material bodies are the basic constituents of the reality we describe and refer to.
- B. Bodies cause our experiences, causes are prior to effects, therefore bodies are prior to the experiences they cause.
- C. Identification requires re-identification; re-identification requires one unified spatio-temporal framework; enduring public bodies occupy it and anchor identification.
- D. Bodies are named in ordinary language, ordinary language is our best guide to reality, therefore bodies are basic.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the conclusion is about conceptual priority within our scheme, not about what is real.
- **B:** Incorrect: the argument is expressly **not** causal; a causal claim would make it a scientific rather than a conceptual thesis.
- **C:** Correct: three linked conditions, followed by the observation that dependent particulars are identified through their relations to bodies, persons, places and times.
- **D:** Incorrect: appeal to ordinary naming without the identification-condition is the caricature of descriptive metaphysics, not the argument.

Examiner trap 18: Describing the framework as a psychological image built out of bodies converts a transcendental argument into empirical speculation and forfeits the point of the question.

MCQ 19. Why sense-data cannot be the basic particulars

Which set of defects disqualifies sense-data from the basic role, on Strawson's argument?

- A. They are theoretical, unobservable and postulated only to explain the causal origin of perception.
- B. They are private, momentary and non-spatial, so they cannot ground public identification, re-identification or a framework.
- C. They are variable between different observers, and therefore cannot support agreement about the colours and shapes of objects.
- D. They are mind-dependent, and mind-dependent items cannot exist when nobody happens to be perceiving them.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: sense-data were introduced precisely as what is directly observed, not as unobservable posits.
- **B:** Correct: each defect independently disqualifies them, and together they show the failure is structural rather than incidental.
- **C:** Incorrect: inter-observer variation is an epistemological worry; Strawson's objection concerns the conditions of reference.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is Berkeley's problem about continued existence, and it is not the identification-based argument of *Individuals*.

Examiner trap 19: Listing only privacy leaves the empiricist free to propose a longer-lived or spatially ordered datum, so all three defects must be stated.

MCQ 20. What the purely auditory world shows

What conclusion does Strawson draw from the thought-experiment of a world containing only sounds?

- A. Objective reference in such a scheme would require an analogue of space - for instance a continuously available master-sound.
- B. Such a scheme is strictly impossible, which proves that visual and tactile material bodies are necessary in any conceivable scheme.
- C. Such a scheme is entirely unproblematic, which shows that space plays no essential role in objective thought at all.
- D. Sounds are themselves basic particulars, so the auditory world is simply another scheme with different basics.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the experiment isolates the individuating role a framework must perform rather than privileging our sensory organisation.
- **B:** Incorrect: Strawson's discussion does not simply prove the auditory scheme impossible, and reading it so invites the anthropocentrism charge.
- **C:** Incorrect: pitch and succession alone do not yet support robust objective re-identification, which is the experiment's finding.
- **D:** Incorrect: sounds are dependent particulars in our scheme, identified through their relations to bodies, places and times.

Examiner trap 20: Writing "a sound-only world is simply impossible" both misreports the text and hands the examiner the anthropocentrism objection that the passage exists to answer.

MCQ 21. The two classes of predicate ascribed to a person

Which statement correctly describes M-predicates and P-predicates?

- A. M-predicates are ascribed to bodies and P-predicates to minds, so a person is a body joined to a mind.
- B. Both are ascribed to a single subject: M-predicates are also true of mere bodies, P-predicates ascribe states of consciousness.
- C. M-predicates are measurable and P-predicates are not, which is why psychology cannot be a quantitative science.
- D. P-predicates are ascribed first and M-predicates only derivatively, since consciousness is given to us long before the body is known.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: splitting the ascriptions between two subjects restores exactly the dualism the doctrine rejects.
- **B:** Correct: "weighs 70 kg" and "is in pain" are both true of the same thing, and that single subject is the person.
- **C:** Incorrect: measurability is not the criterion; the criterion is whether the predicate is also applicable to a mere body.
- **D:** Incorrect: no priority of that kind is claimed, and the Cartesian ordering it presupposes is what Strawson denies.

Examiner trap 21: Attaching the two predicate-classes to two subjects produces a paraphrase of dualism under Strawson's vocabulary, which the examiner will read as a failure to grasp the thesis.

MCQ 22. The dual character of P-predicates

What feature of P-predicates carries the argument for the primitiveness of the person concept?

- A. They are ascribed to others by analogy with one's own case, which is what explains our ordinary knowledge of other minds.
- B. They are incorrigible when self-ascribed, so first-person reports about them cannot be mistaken.
- C. They are other-ascribed on publicly available criteria yet self-ascribed without observation of one's own behaviour.
- D. They are ascribed only to human beings, which is what distinguishes persons from animals and machines.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Strawson rejects the argument from analogy; other-ascription proceeds on public criteria, not on inference to a hidden mind.
- **B:** Incorrect: incorrigibility is a different and stronger claim, and the argument needs only ascription without observation.
- **C:** Correct: a predicate with that dual condition cannot be built from a pure consciousness or from a pure body, so its subject must already be both.
- **D:** Incorrect: the restriction to human beings is not the argument, and it would make the thesis a classification rather than a conceptual claim.

Examiner trap 22: Dropping "without observation" from the self-ascription condition destroys the asymmetry, and without the asymmetry the conclusion simply does not follow.

MCQ 23. What "primitive" means in "the concept of a person is primitive"

Which reading of "primitive" is Strawson's?

- A. Conceptual priority: the concept cannot be constructed from an independently identifiable body plus an independently identifiable consciousness.
- B. Ontological simplicity: persons are metaphysical simples possessing no parts whatever, no internal structure and no constituent elements of any kind.
- C. Epistemic immediacy: we know persons directly, without inference, in a way we do not know material bodies.
- D. Historical primacy: the concept of a person was acquired by human beings before the concept of a body.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: primitiveness is a claim about the order of concepts within our scheme, not about substances, evidence or history.
- **B:** Incorrect: persons plainly have parts; the thesis concerns the analysis of a concept, not the mereology of an entity.
- **C:** Incorrect: no claim of privileged epistemic access is being made, and Strawson's argument turns on public criteria.
- **D:** Incorrect: developmental or historical order is irrelevant to a claim about logical priority.

Examiner trap 23: Treating "primitive" as the postulation of a third substance turns the anti-Cartesian argument into a version of the Cartesianism it was written to displace.

MCQ 24. How the no-ownership theory refutes itself

On Strawson's analysis, why can the no-ownership theorist not state his own thesis?

- A. Because he must deny that he himself has any experiences, which makes his assertion self-contradictory.
- B. Because experiences are self-intimating, so anyone who has one thereby knows that he owns it.
- C. Because causal dependence on a particular body is an empirical scientific claim, and scientific claims cannot settle conceptual questions.
- D. Because to specify which experiences he means he must say "the experiences that are had by this body", and "had by" is possessive.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the theorist does not deny that experiences occur; he denies that they are owned by a subject.
- **B:** Incorrect: self-intimation is a Cartesian thesis about access, not the argument from the statement of the theory.
- **C:** Incorrect: Strawson does not object to causal dependence as such; he objects that dependence cannot do the individuating work ownership does.
- **D:** Correct: the contingent causal relation cannot single out these experiences, so the personal framework is reintroduced in the very statement of the denial.

Examiner trap 24: Refuting only Cartesian dualism on a persons question leaves the second rival standing, and it is the second rival on which Strawson's chapter turns.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - where the bound-variable slogan comes from

"To be is to be the value of a bound variable" summarises a criterion developed in which work?

- A. "On What There Is" (*Review of Metaphysics*, 1948).
- B. "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951).
- C. *Word and Object* (1960), in the chapter on radical translation.
- D. "Ontological Relativity" (Dewey Lectures, 1968; volume 1969).

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the criterion of ontological commitment is developed there, and the slogan is the standard summary of it.
- **B:** Incorrect: "Two Dogmas" is about analyticity, reductionism and holism; the slogan does not belong to it.
- **C:** Incorrect: *Word and Object* ch. 2 supplies radical translation and *gavagai*, not the commitment criterion.
- **D:** Incorrect: the 1968/69 material states ontological **relativity**, which is a different and later thesis.

Examiner trap 25: Sourcing the slogan to "Two Dogmas" is a datable error that an examiner can check in seconds, and it undermines confidence in every other date in the script.

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - the two halves of the quantum-logic episode

Which attribution is correct?

- A. Putnam and Birkhoff jointly proposed quantum logic in 1936 and defended it again in 1968.
- B. Von Neumann argued in 1968 that the distributive law must be revised on empirical grounds.
- C. Birkhoff and von Neumann proposed a non-distributive lattice in 1936; Putnam argued in 1968 that logic is empirically revisable.
- D. Quine proposed the revision of the distributive law in 1951, and Putnam later defended Quine's proposal against its many critics.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it merges two authors, two dates and two different kinds of claim into one non-existent joint proposal.
- **B:** Incorrect: von Neumann's contribution is the 1936 formalism, not the later philosophical thesis.
- **C:** Correct: a formal proposal in 1936 and a philosophical claim in 1968, which Putnam himself later abandoned.
- **D:** Incorrect: Quine resisted the revision of logic, notably in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).

Examiner trap 26: Writing "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, or merging the dates, converts a researched illustration into a demonstrable factual error.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - Quine's own later position on revising logic

What position does Quine take in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970)?

- A. That logic was revised in 1936 and that the revision has been accepted by working physicists since.
- B. That logic is analytic after all, which repairs the analytic/synthetic distinction he had earlier attacked.
- C. That logic is revisable only within constructed artificial languages, and never in the language of everyday scientific practice.
- D. That anyone who "denies" a law of logic has changed the subject, and that revision should observe minimum mutilation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the proposal was contested rather than accepted, and Putnam himself later withdrew from it.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine never restores analyticity; entrenchment remains his account of logic's stability.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such restriction to artificial languages is offered, and it would sit badly with his naturalism.
- **D:** Correct: "change of logic, change of subject" together with the maxim of minimum mutilation is the later, conservative Quine.

Examiner trap 27: Using the early Quine's boldest slogan without the later retreat produces an answer that a well-read examiner can immediately qualify, which is a mark forfeited voluntarily.

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - what "empiricism without the dogmas" retains

Which statement describes Quine's own position after both dogmas are removed?

- A. Sensory evidence and scientific naturalism are retained; sentence-by-sentence reduction and the foundational analytic/synthetic boundary are not.
- B. Empiricism is abandoned in favour of a rationalism that grounds the whole of science in first principles known independently of any experience at all.
- C. Empiricism is replaced by scepticism, since without a foundation no belief can be rationally preferred to any other.
- D. Empiricism survives unchanged, since Quine's criticisms concern only the artificial languages constructed by Carnap.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the title of Section 6 is "Empiricism without the Dogmas", and subtraction rather than replacement is exactly what it describes.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine denies any first-philosophy standpoint, which rules out the rationalist foundation this option supposes.
- **C:** Incorrect: pragmatic virtues and predictive success discriminate between revisions, so scepticism does not follow.
- **D:** Incorrect: the criticism is aimed at the empiricist tradition generally, and Carnap's constructed languages are only one target.

Examiner trap 28: Opening with "Quine rejects empiricism" contradicts the section title of the very paper being discussed and misdescribes his self-understanding.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - why the linguist cannot simply ask

In the *gavagai* argument, why can the field linguist not settle the reference of the term by asking whether this gavagai is the same as that one?

- A. Because the native speakers may be unwilling to cooperate with a stranger's persistent questioning.
- B. Because reference is a theoretical notion and cannot be investigated by any empirical method at all.
- C. Because assent and dissent are unreliable indicators of belief, so no verbal response whatever could count as evidence for anything at all.
- D. Because the question presupposes a translated identity predicate and the whole apparatus of individuation, which is what is in dispute.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: cooperation is stipulated in the thought-experiment; the obstacle is logical, not social.
- **B:** Incorrect: Quine's approach to reference is thoroughly empirical; the argument shows that the empirical evidence underdetermines the answer.
- **C:** Incorrect: assent and dissent are the whole evidential base Quine allows, and he treats them as reliable.
- **D:** Correct: identity, articles, plurals and quantifiers must already be translated for the question to be asked, and their translation is precisely what is undetermined.

Examiner trap 29: Asserting "meanings are indeterminate" without the identity-predicate move states a conclusion whose only support has been omitted.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - four doctrines, four units

Which pairing of doctrine and unit is correct?

- A. Indeterminacy of translation concerns sub-sentential terms, while inscrutability of reference concerns entire translation manuals and theories.
- B. Radical translation and ontological relativity are two names for the same thesis about background theories.
- C. Inscrutability concerns sub-sentential terms; indeterminacy concerns rival manuals; ontological relativity concerns background theories.
- D. Ontological relativity concerns the bound variables of a regimented theory, exactly as the 1948 criterion does.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it swaps the two units; indeterminacy is the manual-level thesis and inscrutability the term-level one.
- **B:** Incorrect: radical translation is the method or situation; ontological relativity is a thesis about how reference is fixed.
- **C:** Correct: four doctrines, four distinct units, and keeping them apart prevents the commonest confusion in this material.
- **D:** Incorrect: the 1948 criterion audits what a regimented theory quantifies over; relativity concerns how reference is fixed at all.

Examiner trap 30: Using "indeterminacy" and "inscrutability" interchangeably signals that the doctrines have been remembered as a story rather than understood as distinct theses.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - dating naturalized epistemology and its governing image

Which statement about naturalized epistemology is correct?

- A. It is stated in "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), whose closing section already proposes a naturalistic psychology of belief-formation.
- B. It is stated in *Individuals* (1959), where Strawson endorses it as a form of descriptive metaphysics.
- C. It is stated in *Word and Object* (1960), whose epigraph from Popper supplies its governing image.
- D. It is stated in "Epistemology Naturalized" in the 1969 volume; the governing image is Neurath's boat, the epigraph of *Word and Object*.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the 1951 paper argues for holism; the naturalisation of epistemology comes nearly two decades later.
- **B:** Incorrect: *Individuals* is Strawson's, and descriptive metaphysics is not a naturalised epistemology.
- **C:** Incorrect: the epigraph of *Word and Object* is **Neurath's** boat, not Popper's, and the essay is not in that book.
- **D:** Correct: the Dewey Lectures were delivered in 1968 and the volume appeared in 1969, containing both "Ontological Relativity" and "Epistemology Naturalized".

Examiner trap 31: Dating naturalized epistemology to 1951 compresses eighteen years of Quine's development and misrepresents "Two Dogmas" as a programme it never announces.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - the ownership fence around this clause

Which item belongs to **another** syllabus clause and must not be expounded as doctrine here?

- A. The argument that identification requires a single unified spatio-temporal framework of material bodies.
- B. The verification principle and its formulation by Ayer and the Vienna Circle, expounded as a doctrine.
- C. The claim that no statement is immune to revision, together with the field-of-force model of belief.
- D. The argument that P-predicates must be ascribable both to others and to oneself, on different grounds.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Strawson's printed doctrine and the core of 2020 Q3(b) and 2021 Q3(b).
- **B:** Correct: Logical Positivism is Topic 07; the verification principle appears here only as the position Quine dismantles.
- **C:** Incorrect: holism and the web are Quine's printed doctrine and the core of 2025 Q4(b).
- **D:** Incorrect: the dual-ascription argument is Strawson's printed doctrine and the core of 2018 Q1(e) and 2023 Q4(a).

Examiner trap 32: Spending a third of a Quine answer expounding the Vienna Circle's verification principle answers a Topic 07 question that was not asked, and the same fence applies to Hume, Kant, Russell's descriptions and Wittgenstein's language-games.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answers for Philosophy Paper I. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the typographic quotation marks the repository ledger records and the printed hyphenation of "synthetic-analytic" in 2019. The 2018 to 2025 Paper I texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Provenance is treated as examinable: "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" is cited to *The Philosophical Review*, **January 1951**, with its web-of-belief passage at **Section 6**; the bound-variable slogan is credited to the criterion of **"On What There Is" (1948)** and never to "Two Dogmas"; *Individuals* (1959) is cited by **Part I** for basic particulars and **chapter 3** for persons; and "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) is attributed to **Grice and Strawson** jointly. Interpretive disputes - whether the failure of explication defeats the ordinary distinction, whether logic is revisable in any interesting sense, whether descriptive metaphysics can be more than a map, and whether "primitive" explains or merely ends the analysis - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **9 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus, with **two each in 2018 and 2021**, one each in **2019, 2020, 2023, 2024 and 2025**, and **none in 2022**. All nine are solved in full below, followed by **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: **Quine** carries five parts (2018 Q2(c), 2019 Q1(e), 2021 Q3(c), 2024 Q4(c), 2025 Q4(b)) and **Strawson** four (2018 Q1(e), 2020 Q3(b), 2021 Q3(b), 2023 Q4(a)); the single 20-marker is Strawson's, and the Strawson parts escalate from a 10-marker on the person concept in 2018 to that 20-marker in 2023. One part - **2025 Q4(b)** - is a **statement question**, and for it the first move is to preserve the conditional clause of the quotation; one part - **2018 Q2(c)** - embeds a **framing phrase**, "a metaphysical article of faith", which is the paper's wording rather than a verified verbatim Quine quotation, and every solution below says so.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he explain " - an argument is required, not a definition
Core issue	That "person" is logically primitive, and why that follows from the way P-predicates work
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the predicate matrix, the argument, both rivals in one sentence each
Ideal thesis	A person is a single subject of two predicate-classes, and the concept cannot be assembled from either half
Non-negotiables	M- and P-predicates with examples; "without observation"; both dualism and no-ownership named

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson explains the person not as a compound of mind and body but as a **logically primitive** concept - the concept of a single subject to which both bodily and mental predicates are ascribed, presupposed by rather than assembled from the concepts of mind and body (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

The predicate matrix. FACT: A person is that to which we ascribe both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen" - and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness - "is in pain", "is thinking of Vienna". Both classes belong to **one** thing.

The argument. I can self-ascribe P-predicates only if the same predicates are ascribable to **others**; others are identified as **embodied subjects** on publicly available behavioural criteria; yet the same predicates are self-ascribed **without observation** of my own behaviour. ANALYSIS: A predicate with that **dual character** cannot be built from a pure consciousness, which never reaches public criteria, or from a pure body, which never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Its subject must already be both.

The two rivals. This undercuts **Cartesian dualism**, which cannot re-identify an immaterial soul in the framework identification requires, and destroys the **no-ownership theory**, which must say "the experiences **had by** this body" and so restores the possession it denied.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: "Primitive" means conceptual priority within our scheme, not a third substance.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the directive is "how does he explain", so the six-step argument, not the definition, is the answer.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; matrix two; argument four; rivals two; qualification one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> matrix -> argument -> two rivals -> qualification.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** conceptual priority against substance-postulation.
- **Criticism:** implicit in the qualification, which blocks both the dualist and the materialist misreading.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does he show " plus "give reasons" - a mechanism, then its grounds
Core issue	That the phrase is the paper's framing and that Quine's case is three connected moves
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: three moves, one Kantian reply, one graded verdict; not a Kant exposition
Ideal thesis	Explication failure, holism and naturalism jointly leave the a priori asserted rather than shown
Non-negotiables	The framing flagged; the 1951 dating; "no statement is immune to revision"; the Kantian reply

Independent model answer

Thesis. ANALYSIS: "A metaphysical article of faith" is the **question's framing**, not a verified verbatim Quine formula; what Quine supplies is a three-step case that a Kantian a priori is asserted rather than established.

Move one - the explication fails. Kant's synthetic a priori presupposes a workable analytic/synthetic boundary. In "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (*The Philosophical Review*, 1951) Quine shows that analyticity can be explained only through **synonymy**, and synonymy only through **definition**, which records an antecedent synonymy; or **interchangeability salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity-operator whose intelligibility rests on analyticity; or Carnap's **semantical rules**, which yield "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion. Every route returns to its starting point.

Move two - holism. Because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body", **any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere**, and **no statement is immune to revision**. Apparent apriority is therefore greater **centrality** in the web - a difference of degree, not of kind.

Move three - naturalism. Philosophy is continuous with science and there is no first-philosophy standpoint from which a priori knowledge could be certified. To assert it is to take on trust what cannot be shown.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Kant may answer that transcendental conditions of experience are not empirical hypotheses inside the web, so revisability does not reach them - a reply Strawson's descriptive reading of Kant supports. Quine's rejoinder is that this reasserts precisely the privileged non-empirical status in dispute.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Quine defeats a **sharp** a priori/a posteriori boundary; what survives is a gradient of entrenchment, and whether some framework role escapes the web remains open.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question is about **Quine's** argument; Kant appears as its target and as one reply, never as an exposition.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; move one six; move two four; move three two; objection two; verdict two.

- **Structure:** framing flagged -> three moves -> reply -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** circle of explication; holism; naturalism.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); both canonical sentences; the three failed routes.
- **Distinction:** degree of entrenchment against difference in kind.
- **Criticism:** the transcendental-conditions reply, reported as unsettled.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain ... arguments" - plural, so the chain must be reproduced
Core issue	The circularity of every candidate explication, and the exact conclusion drawn
Scope boundary	Ten marks: two classes, three routes, conclusion, one objection
Ideal thesis	No non-circular explication is available, so the distinction cannot bear foundational weight
Non-negotiables	The heart/kidney case; the necessity regress; "analytic-in-L"; Grice and Strawson

Independent model answer

Thesis. Quine argues that the distinction admits no principled, **non-circular** criterion: every proposed explanation of "analytic" presupposes a notion from the same family.

The two classes. FACT: Analytic truths were said to be either **logically true** - "No unmarried man is married" - or convertible into logical truths by substituting **synonyms** - "No bachelor is married". The second class needs synonymy, and that is where the trouble begins.

Three routes, three failures. **Definition** merely *records* a synonymy already present in the language, except where frankly stipulative. **Interchangeability salva veritate*** over-generates in an extensional language - "creature with a heart" and "creature with a kidney" interchange without being synonymous - and repairing it by demanding interchange within "necessarily" presupposes a **necessity** intelligible for Quine only through analyticity. **Semantical rules** deliver "analytic-in-L" by stipulation, leaving the general notion no clearer than what it was to explain.

The conclusion, stated exactly. ANALYSIS: Not that "All bachelors are unmarried" is false, but that the available explications fail to secure the **sharp foundational boundary** logical empiricism required. What replaces it is **degrees of entrenchment** in the web of belief.

Objection and reply. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) reply that a distinction with agreed application is not discredited by the absence of a reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder: agreed sorting is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion needed.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the marks are in the **circle**, so each route must be shown returning to synonymy or necessity.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; classes two; routes five; conclusion two; objection two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> two classes -> three routes -> exact conclusion -> objection.
- **Doctrine:** synonymy, definition, *salva veritate*, semantical rules.
- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney counter-case; "analytic-in-L"; the 1956 reply.
- **Distinction:** failure of explication against falsity of the sentences.
- **Criticism:** Grice and Strawson, with the rejoinder rather than a bare mention.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2020 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Evaluate the role" - a function must be identified, then assessed
Core issue	That a single spatio-temporal framework is the condition of objective identification
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the argument, the auditory test, the limitation
Ideal thesis	Spatio-temporal thinking supplies the individuating framework without which re-identification, and so objectivity, is impossible
Non-negotiables	Identification -> re-identification -> framework; the three defects; the analogue of space

Independent model answer

Thesis. Spatio-temporal thinking is not one feature of objective thought among others: it supplies the **single framework** without which particulars cannot be re-identified, and without re-identification there is no objective reference at all.

The argument. FACT: In *Individuals* (1959, Part I) Strawson argues that to identify a particular I must distinguish it from others and **re-identify** it across time; re-identification requires **one unified spatio-temporal framework** in which every particular has a location; and **material bodies**, as enduring and publicly observable occupants of that framework, are the standard anchors of demonstrative identification. Experiences, events and sounds are **dependent** particulars, identified through their relations to persons, bodies, places and times.

Why the empiricist alternative fails. Sense-data cannot supply a framework: they are **private**, so they cannot ground public identification; **momentary**, so they cannot be re-identified; and **non-spatial**, so they cannot constitute a framework at all. Material bodies are therefore basic as a **condition of the possibility of reference**, not as a metaphysical preference.

The evaluative test. ANALYSIS: Strawson removes space to see what it was doing. A purely auditory world of pitch and succession cannot distinguish the same particular re-encountered from a new one exactly resembling it; objective reference there would require an **analogue of space**, reconstructed through a continuously available **master-sound**. The experiment therefore isolates the **individuating role** rather than privileging our sensory organisation.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The result is transcendental in form and internal in reach: it establishes what **our conceptual scheme** requires, not that reality independently contains bodies. CAUTION: An empiricist may accept the analysis as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology - and conceding this strengthens the answer.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "evaluate the role" is answered by removing the thing whose role is in question; the auditory world is therefore the centre, not an ornament.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; argument five; failure three; test four; verdict three.

- **Structure:** thesis -> argument -> why sense-data fail -> the removal test -> limitation.
- **Doctrine:** identification, re-identification, unified framework, dependent particulars.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I; the three defects; the master-sound.
- **Distinction:** individuating **role** against our particular sensory equipment.
- **Criticism:** the internal, scheme-relative reach of the conclusion.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2021 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Definition, then reasons , then "critically discuss" - three obligations
Core issue	Two kinds of basic particular, each with its own argument
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both arguments compressed, then two objections with replies
Ideal thesis	Bodies are basic by the identification argument, persons by the dual-ascription argument
Non-negotiables	Both kinds answered; the three defects; M/P predicates; anthropocentrism and the "primitive" objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. Basic particulars are those on which the possibility of **identification and reference in general** depends; Strawson argues that **material bodies** and **persons** occupy that role in our conceptual scheme, each by a distinct argument.

Bodies. FACT: Identification requires **re-identification**; re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**; and material bodies are its enduring, publicly observable occupants, anchoring demonstrative identification (*Individuals*, 1959, Part I). Sense-data cannot take the role: they are **private, momentary and non-spatial**. Experiences, events and sounds are identified only through their relations to bodies, persons, places and times.

Persons. FACT: A person is a single subject bearing both **M-predicates** - "weighs 70 kg" - and **P-predicates** - "is in pain" (ch. 3). Self-ascription of P-predicates is possible only if they are **other-ascribable** on public criteria, while remaining **self-ascribable without observation**. A predicate with that dual character cannot be constructed from a pure body or a pure consciousness, so the concept of a person is **logically primitive** - the second kind of basic particular.

Critical assessment. CAUTION: First, the argument is charged with **anthropocentrism**: another scheme might not need bodies. Strawson's conclusion always concerned **our** scheme, and the purely auditory discussion concedes that an **analogue of space** could perform the individuating role - a measured reply rather than a refutation. CAUTION: Second, calling the person concept "primitive" may **end** analysis rather than explain the psychophysical unity. Strawson's defenders answer that the demand for analysis into mind plus body already presupposes dualism, so refusal is the point; but the mechanism of unity is genuinely untouched.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The reasons succeed as **descriptive metaphysics**: they establish what our scheme requires, not what exists independently of it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the stem names **two** kinds of basic particular, so an answer that argues only for bodies has answered half the question.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; bodies four; persons four; assessment five; verdict one.

- **Structure:** definition -> bodies -> persons -> two objections with replies -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** identification/re-identification; the dual character of P-predicates.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) Part I and ch. 3; the three defects; the master-sound concession.
- **Distinction:** two different arguments for two kinds of basic particular.
- **Criticism:** anthropocentrism and the explanatory limits of "primitive".

Solved PYQ 6 · 2021 · Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	" Critically examine " - assessment must occupy a substantial share
Core issue	What empiricism retains once both dogmas are removed
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: both dogmas compressed, holism, then the objections
Ideal thesis	The dogmas are removed and empiricism survives, reformed rather than refuted
Non-negotiables	Both dogmas; "at root identical"; the pragmatic virtues; Grice-Strawson; the arbitrariness objection

Independent model answer

Thesis. Quine's postulate is **subtraction, not replacement**: two assumptions are removed and what survives - sensory evidence and scientific naturalism - is still empiricism, now holistic and thoroughly revisable.

The two dogmas. FACT: The first is the belief in a principled analytic/synthetic boundary; it fails because **definition, interchangeability salva veritate*** and **semantical rules** each presuppose synonymy, necessity or analyticity. The second is **reductionism**: the assumption that each statement has its own confirming experiences, whether by translation into a sense-datum language or by individual confirmation. ANALYSIS: Quine's own verdict is that the two are **at root identical**, since statements "confirmed come what may" need a contrast class of individually confirmed statements.

What replaces them. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**"; the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**; and revision, forced somewhere by a recalcitrant experience, is located by **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity** rather than by logic.

What survives. FACT: Experience remains the check on the system, science remains the best account of what there is, and there is **no first philosophy** outside it. The line between speculative metaphysics and natural science becomes one of **degree**.

Critical assessment. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma", 1956) object that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive definition; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy, and the dispute is really about **standards of explication**. CAUTION: The arbitrariness charge - if everything is revisable, nothing constrains belief - is met by pragmatic conservatism and, in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970), by the **maxim of minimum mutilation**.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**; the postulate stands in its reformed, not its most radical, version.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "critically examine" requires the assessment to be a section, not a closing sentence.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; dogmas five; replacement three; survival two; assessment four; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> both dogmas -> holism -> what survives -> objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; reductionism in two forms; the corporate body; entrenchment.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956); *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** subtraction against rejection of empiricism.
- **Criticism:** standards of explication; the arbitrariness charge and its constraints.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2023 · Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A why , then an implication - two questions, both answered explicitly
Core issue	That both rival accounts presuppose the concept they try to construct or eliminate
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the frame, the argument, both rivals, a graded verdict
Ideal thesis	Person is prior to mind and body, so the dualist question is dissolved rather than answered
Non-negotiables	Descriptive frame; M/P predicates; the dual character; dualism and no-ownership; the cost

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson holds the concept of a person to be **logically primitive** because both rival accounts of the mind-body relation presuppose it; the implication for dualism is not refutation of a thesis but **dissolution of its starting point**.

The frame. FACT: *Individuals* (1959) is **descriptive metaphysics**: it describes the actual structure of our thought rather than proposing a better one. The question is therefore what our scheme of ascribing predicates to persons requires.

Why primitive. FACT: In our scheme a person is a single entity bearing both **M-predicates**, also true of mere bodies - "weighs 70 kg", "is in the kitchen" - and **P-predicates**, ascribing states of consciousness - "is in pain", "intends to leave". The decisive feature is the **dual character** of P-predicates: they are ascribed to **others** on publicly available behavioural and situational criteria, and to **oneself without observation** of one's own behaviour. ANALYSIS: From a pure consciousness one never reaches public criteria, so other-ascription is impossible; from a pure body one never reaches unobserved self-ascription. Only a subject that is already **both** satisfies both conditions, and the concept of that subject is therefore **prior** to the concepts of mind and body - "logically prior to that of an individual consciousness".

The implication for dualism. FACT: Cartesian dualism treats an independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior; but an immaterial soul cannot be located in the single spatio-temporal framework in which identification and **re-identification** occur, and once the two substances are separated their interaction becomes unintelligible. Strawson does not answer the interaction question - he shows that it presupposes a prior unity neither term can supply. ANALYSIS: The **no-ownership theory** fares no better: to say which experiences are in question the theorist must say "the experiences **had by** this body", and the possessive restores the ownership he denied.

Assessment. CAUTION: The strength is economy: the problem is **dissolved** because the decomposition generating it is illicit. The cost is that "primitive" marks the **end of analysis** rather than an explanation of psychophysical unity - legitimate for descriptive metaphysics, unsatisfying for anyone who wanted the problem solved. ANALYSIS: And the conclusion is scheme-relative: dualism's **starting point** is undercut, not every dualist thesis disproved.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the second question is the marked one; the exposition must be arranged so that the implication is earned rather than announced.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis one line; frame two; why primitive eight; implication seven; assessment four.

- **Structure:** thesis -> descriptive frame -> the argument -> dualism -> no-ownership -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** primitiveness; predicate duality; dissolution rather than solution.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; four predicate examples; the possessive "had by".
- **Distinction:** undercutting a **starting point** against refuting every dualist thesis.
- **Criticism:** the end-of-analysis cost, conceded and correctly located.

Solved PYQ 8 · 2024 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the nature " - what each dogma is, and what makes each a dogma
Core issue	Both dogmas defined, both refuted, and the relation between them stated
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: definitions, the refutations, the identification, one criticism
Ideal thesis	Two unargued assumptions, structurally the same, both removed by holism
Non-negotiables	Both forms of reductionism; the label explained; "at root identical"

Independent model answer

Thesis. The two dogmas are unargued assumptions of logical empiricism - a principled analytic/synthetic boundary and sentence-by-sentence confirmation - and Quine's case is that they are **at root identical**.

The first dogma. FACT: It is the belief that there is a non-arbitrary line between statements true **by virtue of meaning** and statements true **by virtue of fact**. It is a dogma because the line cannot be drawn non-circularly: analyticity requires **synonymy**; synonymy is explained by **definition**, which merely records an antecedent synonymy, or by **interchangeability salva veritate***, which over-generates extensionally ("creature with a heart" / "creature with a kidney") and requires a necessity-operator that presupposes analyticity, or by Carnap's **semantical rules**, which give "analytic-in-L" without explaining the general notion.

The second dogma. FACT: **Reductionism** is the belief that each meaningful statement is translatable into, or individually confirmable by, a range of sense-experience. Its **radical** form demands term-by-term translation into a sense-datum language; its **attenuated** form abandons translation but keeps individual confirmation. ANALYSIS: The label names the operation: it *reduces* sentence-meaning to observation sentences.

Why both fall together. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**. ANALYSIS: Once no statement has its own evidential stock, the class of statements "confirmed come what may" has no contrast class - which is why Quine calls the two dogmas at root identical.

Assessment. CAUTION: Grice and Strawson (1956) object that the first distinction is intelligible in ordinary use without a reductive analysis; Quine replies that ordinary intelligibility is not the principled ground the positivist meaning-criterion required.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: What replaces both is **empiricism without the dogmas**: holistic, revisable and still empiricist.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "nature" asks what each dogma **is** and why it deserves the name; the identification of the two is what turns a list into an argument.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis one line; first dogma five; second dogma four; identification three; assessment two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> dogma one -> dogma two -> why they fall together -> objection -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the circle; radical and attenuated reductionism; the corporate body.
- **Evidence:** the heart/kidney case; "analytic-in-L"; the unit of empirical significance.
- **Distinction:** the two forms of reductionism, and the explanation of the label.
- **Criticism:** the 1956 reply with Quine's rejoinder.

Solved PYQ 9 · 2025 · Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	A statement question : locate the sentence in the system, then unpack it
Core issue	That the conditional clause is the doctrine, and that it is a claim about confirmation
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the mechanism, the historical illustration, the constraints, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The sentence states holistic confirmation, not licence: the cost is what disciplines the choice
Non-negotiables	<i>Modus tollens</i> ; the three revision options; Neptune and "Vulcan"; minimum mutilation

Independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence is a claim about **where blame for a failed prediction may be assigned**, not a licence to believe anything: the clause "just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere" names the price, and the price is the doctrine.

Where it sits. FACT: It belongs to Section 6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), after both dogmas have been removed. Statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**", so the unit of empirical significance is the whole of science.

The mechanism. FACT: A hypothesis entails an observation only with **auxiliaries**: the testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$. When experience yields not-O, **modus tollens*** delivers only not- $(H \ \& \ A)$ - H is false **or** some element of A is false - and logic never names the guilty conjunct. Three responses are therefore available: revise a peripheral belief, revise a deep interior statement, or **plead hallucination** and revise the observation itself. The third is what makes the quoted sentence literally true.

The historical illustration. FACT: Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were met by revising the auxiliary assumption about the number of planets, and **Neptune** was found (1846). The identical strategy applied to Mercury produced the hypothesised planet "**Vulcan**", which does not exist; there the correct revision was the deep one - **general relativity** (1915). ANALYSIS: Same logical situation, opposite correct responses, no advance rule.

What blocks relativism. ANALYSIS: Revision is chosen on grounds of **simplicity, conservatism and fecundity**, and in *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine adds the **maxim of minimum mutilation** and warns that "change of logic" is change of subject. No statement is revisable **by nature**; only by choice, and choice has costs.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The statement is right about confirmation and easily misread as relativism; truncating it at "come what may" is what produces the misreading.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: a statement question is failed by paraphrase; the answer must supply the mechanism the sentence compresses.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; location two; mechanism five; illustration four; constraints two; verdict one.

- **Structure:** thesis -> location in Section 6 -> *modus tollens* -> Neptune/Vulcan -> constraints -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holistic confirmation; the three revision options.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951) Section 6; Neptune 1846; "Vulcan" and general relativity 1915; *Philosophy of Logic* (1970).
- **Distinction:** re-allocating blame against indifference to evidence.
- **Criticism:** the relativist misreading identified and diagnosed.

Six original questions in the style of the paper - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks - covering the parts of the course the 2018-2025 corpus has not yet examined directly: the Duhem-Quine mechanism on its own, descriptive against revisionary metaphysics, the revisability of logic, the no-ownership theory, the indeterminacy of translation, and the two-project comparison. Every model answer is independent learner practice.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why, for Quine, no single scientific hypothesis can be tested in isolation.

Independent model answer

Thesis. A hypothesis makes no prediction by itself, so experience never convicts it alone; what is tested is always a **conjunction**.

The mechanism. FACT: The testable claim is $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$, where A gathers background theory, instrument theory and initial conditions. Observation yields **not-O**, and **modus tollens*** delivers only **not-(H & A)**: H is false or some element of A is false. Logic does not say which.

The consequence. ANALYSIS: A reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences therefore has no application - which is precisely Quine's second dogma. And symmetrically, "any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system".

The evidence. FACT: Anomalies in Uranus's orbit were resolved by revising an auxiliary, and **Neptune** was found in **1846**; the same move applied to Mercury produced "**Vulcan**", which does not exist, and the correct revision proved to be **general relativity (1915)**. Identical logical situations, opposite correct responses.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: **Duhem (1906)** confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; the extension to all knowledge is Quine's own step. Nor does the thesis make revision arbitrary: simplicity, conservatism and minimum mutilation still discriminate.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the logical form is the answer; the history is what proves it is not a mere possibility.

- **Structure:** thesis $\rightarrow$ *modus tollens* $\rightarrow$ consequence for dogma two $\rightarrow$ paired historical case $\rightarrow$ qualification.
- **Doctrine:** the conjunction under test; holistic confirmation.
- **Evidence:** Neptune 1846; "Vulcan"; general relativity 1915; Duhem 1906.
- **Distinction:** Duhem's restricted thesis against Quine's extension.
- **Criticism:** the arbitrariness worry, answered by pragmatic constraints.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics, and explain why Strawson describes his own project as descriptive.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Descriptive metaphysics describes the actual structure of our thought about the world; revisionary metaphysics proposes a better structure - and Strawson's project is descriptive because its conclusions are claims about the conditions of a scheme we already use.

The distinction. FACT: In *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics (1959)* the descriptive metaphysician maps how our concepts hang together; the revisionary metaphysician recommends replacing them. Strawson's own examples are **Aristotle** and **Kant** on the descriptive side, and **Descartes**, **Leibniz** and **Berkeley** on the revisionary side.

The relation. ANALYSIS: The two are not simply opposed: revisionary metaphysics is at its most valuable **in the service of** the descriptive, because dismantling part of the actual scheme reveals what it was doing.

Why Strawson's project is descriptive. FACT: His method is **connective analysis**: concepts are exhibited in their dependence on one another, not reduced to a privileged base of simples. His arguments are **transcendental in form** - from an undisputed fact about identification or ascription to its conditions - and their conclusions are therefore about

our scheme.

Qualification. CAUTION: The programme is charged with being circular or conservative, since it protects the scheme in which its conditions are stated. Strawson accepts an **internal** task: even radical revision must begin inside some functioning scheme of identification and reference. The cost is that description alone cannot show the scheme uniquely correct.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the fatal error here is two definitions with no examples; Strawson's own names are the cheapest marks available.

- **Structure:** thesis -> distinction with examples -> relation -> why descriptive -> objection and cost.
- **Doctrine:** connective analysis; transcendental form.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) and its subtitle; Aristotle and Kant; Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley.
- **Distinction:** describing against replacing a conceptual scheme.
- **Criticism:** the conservatism charge, answered by the internality of the task.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "No statement is immune to revision." How far can this claim be sustained in the case of logic?

Independent model answer

Thesis. The claim can be sustained **in principle** and only weakly in practice: logic is protected by entrenchment and by the cost of revision rather than by any certificate of analyticity.

The claim and its source. FACT: It stands in Section 6 of "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) as the converse of "any statement can be held true come what may". The early essay extends revisability even to a law of logic, mentioning the proposed revision of the law of excluded middle as a means of simplifying quantum mechanics.

The strongest candidate. FACT: **Birkhoff and von Neumann**, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics" (*Annals of Mathematics*, 1936), proposed a **non-distributive lattice** of quantum propositions - a formal proposal. ANALYSIS: The distinct philosophical claim that logic is therefore **empirically revisable**, and specifically that the **distributive law** should be given up, is **Putnam's**, in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968). WRONG: The two must never be merged into "Putnam/Birkhoff". CAUTION: Putnam later abandoned the position.

The resistance, from Quine himself. ANALYSIS: In *Philosophy of Logic* (1970) Quine argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely **changed the subject**, and he invokes the **maxim of minimum mutilation**. The later Quine is therefore a poor witness for the earlier Quine's boldest claim.

Assessment. CAUTION: The objection that unrestricted revisability leaves science without a fixed point is met by the formula that no statement is revisable **by nature**, only by **choice** - and choice is disciplined by conservatism, simplicity and predictive success. But the concession is substantial: if revising logic normally costs more than any theory can pay, "revisable" does little work.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Holism is right about **confirmation** and overstated about **revisability**. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation: testing is holistic, the choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that little follows from it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "how far" demands a graded ruling, and the grading must be earned by the 1936/1968/1970 sequence rather than asserted.

- **Structure:** thesis -> source of the claim -> the candidate case -> Quine's own retreat -> assessment -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** revisability by choice rather than by nature; minimum mutilation.
- **Evidence:** Birkhoff and von Neumann 1936; Putnam 1968 and his later withdrawal; *Philosophy of Logic* 1970.
- **Distinction:** a formal proposal against a philosophical claim about it.
- **Criticism:** the attenuation objection, conceded and priced.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Examine Strawson's criticism of the no-ownership theory of the self.

Independent model answer

Thesis. Strawson's criticism is that the no-ownership theory cannot be **stated** without reinstating the ownership it denies, so it refutes itself in the act of formulation.

The theory, fairly stated. FACT: The no-ownership or **no-subject** theory - which Strawson reconstructs and criticises, tracing it through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers - holds that experiences are **causally dependent** on a particular body but are not literally **possessed** by any subject. Its motive is respectable: it avoids the Cartesian ego while acknowledging the evident dependence of experience on a body.

The criticism. FACT: To state the thesis the theorist must say **which** experiences he is discussing, and he can only say "all the experiences **that are had by** this body". "Had by" is a **possessive** relation. Contingent causal dependence cannot replace it, because dependence does not single out **these** experiences as one person's rather than another's. The framework of personal ownership therefore returns inside the denial.

The positive alternative. FACT: The reason ownership cannot be removed is that **P-predicates** - "is in pain", "believes it will rain" - must be ascribable to **others** on publicly available criteria and to **oneself without observation**. A predicate with that dual condition presupposes a single subject bearing both **M-** and **P-predicates**; the concept of that subject, the **person**, is therefore **logically primitive** (*Individuals*, 1959, ch. 3).

Assessment. CAUTION: The argument is powerful against the theory as formulated, but it is a **conceptual** result: it shows that our scheme of ascription requires an owner, not that a metaphysically ownerless psychology is incoherent in every possible description. ANALYSIS: And "primitive" ends the analysis rather than explaining how one subject bears both predicate-classes.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The no-ownership theory is destroyed on its own terms; the deeper question of psychophysical unity is dissolved rather than answered.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: state the target theory sympathetically before demolishing it; the demolition is worthless against a straw man.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the theory and its motive -> the possessive move -> the positive alternative -> assessment.
- **Doctrine:** ownership; P-predicate duality; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** *Individuals* (1959) ch. 3; the formula "the experiences had by this body".
- **Distinction:** causal dependence against possession.
- **Criticism:** the scheme-relative reach of the result.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Critically examine Quine's thesis of the indeterminacy of translation. Does it establish that there are no determinate meanings?

Independent model answer

Thesis. The thesis follows validly from Quine's premises but establishes its conclusion **only for those who already accept his naturalism**; what survives independently is the negative result that observable use does not fix reference.

The construction. FACT: In *Word and Object* (1960, ch. 2) a field linguist must build a manual for an unknown language from **assent and dissent under stimulation**. A rabbit runs past; the native says "**Gavagai**"; the linguist writes "Rabbit". But the same **stimulus meaning** fits "**undetached rabbit-parts**", "**a temporal stage of a rabbit**", "**rabbithood**", and the feature-placing "it's rabbiting". ANALYSIS: He cannot simply ask whether this gavagai is the same as that one: the question presupposes a translated **identity predicate** and the whole **apparatus of individuation**, which is exactly what is in dispute.

The two results. FACT: Compensating adjustments preserve every behavioural prediction, so behavioural evidence does not determine reference - **inscrutability of reference**. Extending upward, rival **analytical hypotheses** yield manuals agreeing on all **observation sentences** while translating theoretical sentences into non-equivalent English - **indeterminacy of translation**. ANALYSIS: There are then no determinate **meanings** as entities, so synonymy loses

its anchor and the first dogma's key notion loses its foundation.

The premises where objections enter. ANALYSIS: **P1**: behaviourism about the *evidence* - in linguistics, Quine says, one has no choice, since language is learned wholly from public behaviour. **P2**: the move from behavioural equivalence to "no further fact" is a substantive commitment. **P3**: naturalism denies any standpoint from which meanings could be certified.

The objections. CAUTION: **Chomsky** ("Quine's Empirical Assumptions", 1969): indeterminacy is merely the ordinary **underdetermination of theory by evidence**; if that does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine replies that in physics there is a fact our theories imperfectly track, while in translation nothing beyond dispositions could make a manual right - an **asymmetry** that is a naturalist thesis rather than a result of the argument. CAUTION: **Searle and Evans**: applied reflexively it entails that I do not determinately know what I mean; Quine accepts a version - we **acquiesce in our mother tongue**. ANALYSIS: **Davidson** ("Radical Interpretation", 1973) accepts indeterminacy but confines it to something like a choice of measurement scale - real but harmless.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The thesis does **not** establish that there are no meanings *tout court*; it establishes that there are no determinate meanings **as entities** fixed by behavioural evidence. The durable result is that use alone does not fix reference - a conclusion the later Wittgenstein reaches by another route.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the question contains a second, narrower question; the verdict must answer it in the terms in which it was asked.

- **Structure:** thesis -> the construction -> the two results -> the premises -> three objections -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** stimulus meaning; analytical hypotheses; inscrutability against indeterminacy.
- **Evidence:** *Word and Object* (1960) ch. 2; the four rival readings; Chomsky 1969; Davidson 1973.
- **Distinction:** meanings as entities against the intelligibility of meaningful use.
- **Criticism:** the behaviourist premise identified as the load-bearing one.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Quine and Strawson criticise empiricism, but they do not criticise it together." Discuss.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement is correct: the two attack empiricism at different levels with different tools, and the only documented exchange between them is a **disagreement**.

Quine's level - confirmation. FACT: "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) removes two assumptions. The **analytic/synthetic** boundary fails because definition merely records synonymy, interchangeability *salva veritate* over-generates extensionally and requires a necessity that presupposes analyticity, and semantical rules give only "analytic-in-L". **Reductionism** fails because statements "face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a **corporate body**". What replaces both is **confirmation holism**, and what survives is **empiricism without the dogmas** - sensory evidence and naturalism retained.

Strawson's level - reference. FACT: *Individuals* (1959) argues that identification requires **re-identification**, that re-identification requires a **single unified spatio-temporal framework**, and that **material bodies** are its enduring, publicly observable occupants. Sense-data cannot occupy the role: they are **private, momentary** and **non-spatial**. And since **P-predicates** must be other-ascribed on public criteria yet self-ascribed **without observation**, the concept of a **person** is **logically primitive**, destroying the **no-ownership** alternative as well as the Cartesian one.

Why this is not a joint critique. ANALYSIS: The methods are opposed. Quine is a **naturalist** who regiments science into canonical notation and denies any first philosophy; Strawson practises **connective analysis** and offers arguments that are **transcendental in form**. Their conclusions differ correspondingly: Quine ends with a revisable web in which no statement is immune; Strawson ends with conditions internal to a conceptual scheme that his method is not designed to revise. FACT: And the decisive evidence is textual: **Grice and Strawson**, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956), defend the very distinction Quine attacked, arguing that a distinction with agreed application needs no reductive analysis. Quine's rejoinder - that ordinary intelligibility is not theoretical legitimacy - leaves a live dispute about **standards of explication**, not a shared programme.

What may legitimately be said jointly. ANALYSIS: Empiricism failed twice over: about how theories are **confirmed** and about how we so much as **refer**. That is a problem-field, not a thesis.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: Read together they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction **without becoming one school**; and an answer that treats them as co-authors of a single anti-empiricist doctrine misdescribes the only exchange the record contains.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the quoted claim must be **tested**, not illustrated; the 1956 paper is the evidence that decides it.

- **Structure:** thesis -> Quine's level -> Strawson's level -> why not joint -> the legitimate joint sentence -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** holism; identification and re-identification; primitiveness.
- **Evidence:** "Two Dogmas" (1951); *Individuals* (1959); "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956).
- **Distinction:** naturalism and regimentation against connective, transcendental analysis.
- **Criticism:** the standards-of-explication dispute, reported as unsettled.